

Meeting Minutes

Pedestrian Advisory Committee

June 10th, 2020 @ 7pm

Remote meeting via Zoom

Members Participating: Anita Johnson, Kerri Ann Tester, David Trevvett, Frank Caro, John Shreffler, Robert Sloane, Adelaide Ketchum

Others in Attendance: Jane Ross

The meeting was convened by chair David Trevvett at approximately 7:10 p.m., when a quorum was present on the virtual meeting platform.

1. Public Comment Period for Issues Not on Agenda

No public comment.

2. March 11th minutes

Approved by unanimous roll-call vote..

3. Brief Updates on Recent Developments

Walk signals not automated on State-controlled streets

Signals such as those on Boylston St, will not be put on hands-free because they are under MassDOT control, not the town of Brookline. Brookline had requested the step, but that request was rejected by the state agencies. No action.

Davis Path footbridge

Abby Swaine had sent notification to this committee when the bridge was first closed. The bridge passes over an MBTA line. DPW's project manager has been sending weekly updates about the planned demolition of the bridge, which had been deemed unsafe. This committee needs to wait for an update after the demolition before we can take any action. No action.

Harvard-Thorndike intersection

Residents near Harvard at Thorndike have reached out to this committee with questions about whether curb extensions that were recently installed might not be making that intersection more dangerous for pedestrians crossing at the corners where the curb extensions were not installed. Observations by Pedestrian Advisory Committee chair David Trevvett led to the conclusion that, as claimed by Town staff, the curb extensions are not at fault. Also, increased speed of motorists on the less heavily trafficked motorway during the COVID19 shutdown may have

exacerbated the problem since it was first reported in early March. A list of options to offer to concerned residents was generated and include

- Asking the town to establish lower speed limits in the area based on the new program that was successful around Robinson Park
- Installing new yield to pedestrian signs
- Installing mid Street stanchions informing cars to be aware of and yield to pedestrians in the crosswalks

David Trevvett agreed to write a response including these suggestions and a specific request for a “Yield to Pedestrians” stanchion and send it to the Transportation Division, as well as to the residents who had reached out to us initially.

Pedestrian concerns during the COVID19 shutdown

The Transportation Board and the Town are now reconsidering previously approved budgeted items. This committee is unsure whether any pedestrian related items will potentially be affected, although it was agreed that we should remain vigilant on two specific items, which are traffic calming measures and repainting road markings. The 2021 budget is still in flux. No action.

MBTA shutdowns

Concerns had been expressed over the original planned use of Yankee coach vehicles, which are not accessible to people with mobility impairments, as replacement transportation along Beacon Street during the C-Line shut-down in July. The MBTA has subsequently agreed to using standard MBTA buses as well, these are more accessible. This committee is not aware of any strictly pedestrian-related issues with the shut-down, apart from the general & ongoing prioritization of motor vehicle flow over other users of public ways. It was agreed that ongoing vigilance will be required, especially in July and August during the implementation of the MBTA shutdowns.

The committee explored various ways of soliciting feedback from the public about issues they might encounter during this period. Suggestions included a Google form, an email address, BrookOnline, or some other structure perhaps set up and publicized by Town staff. David Trevette agreed to reach out to the Transportation Department and the Transportation Board regarding how public feedback can best be captured regarding any pedestrian related issues during the MBTA shutdown this summer.

Massachusetts Commission for the Blind

This committee is unsure to whom Meg Robinson (from Massachusetts Commission for the Blind) had sent a request regarding the need for better barriers along the extended sidewalk spaces to facilitate their use by low-vision pedestrians. Todd Kirrane was not able to find any communication from her to him. David Trevvett will reply to her and update her with the bad news that the Transportation Department is unlikely to have money in its budget for any additional accommodations for pedestrians with visual impairments.

4. Changes to the Brookline streetscape during and following the COVID19 crisis

It was agreed that the Pedestrian Advisory Committee should take this opportunity to contribute to the discussion. The primary question is whether we agree that the current COVID19 related changes are working and should remain.

Frank Caro commented that the sidewalk widening efforts were an admirable gesture but questionable in practical terms. The choices of sites and the process for choosing the sites were not ideal. Some sidewalks were widened in places where pedestrian traffic is too light to be of much use, while in other heavily trafficked sidewalk areas, the sidewalks were not widened, such as in front of the post office on Beacon Street in Coolidge Corner. Robert stated concern about traffic after businesses begin to reopen as well as the spacing of existing cones, for example on Longwood. He felt the spacing of cones works well in some spots, for example on eastbound Beacon Street near Coolidge Corner. Many of these efforts are appreciated but need to be implemented more effectively. Other committee members commented that the traffic patterns during the COVID19 shutdown have been unusual. Commuters aren't commuting as often or in the same ways that they were before. That will also be changing going forward.

It was agreed that this Committee should keep a close eye on changing traffic patterns in coming weeks and months.

Committee members also noted that many drivers are ignoring demarcations of the widened pedestrian and cyclist areas, and some are even moving the cones to make room for vehicle parking. Regular, strict ticketing of such vehicles seems to be the only possible deterrent to this bad behavior, but so far this has not been happening. Robert noted the significant risk of the Town's losing these valuable sidewalk widening accommodations if they are not implemented well and therefore not well used by pedestrians, i.e., if pedestrians do not feel comfortable using these improved spaces.

Frank encouraged this Committee, the Transportation Board, and Town staff to concentrate on better implementation of the sidewalk widening efforts that are truly needed. He also remarked that better enforcement is needed for drivers who violate the new regulations. He suggested compiling a "short list" of sites with current extended pedestrian accommodations that seem to really need them and to ask the Town for better implementation on those sites. Robert reminded the Committee that we need information in order to compile this list. Adelaide remarked on the dangers of mixing cyclists and pedestrians and the trickiness of making sure that the safety of all public way users is safeguarded. David noted that the town is moving from phase one to phase two in Governor Baker's reopening plan and that traffic patterns are changing and will continue to change in coming weeks and months. He recommended that we find an existing pedestrian accommodations plan that works and lend our support to it. Robert recommended considering supporting Jules Milner-Brage's plan (continued in his prior e-mail to the

Transportation Board, shared with our Committee). David Trevvett suggested voicing additional support for the Bridleway plan while acknowledging an issue related to funding.

It was agreed that Frank, Robert, and David will begin to compile the short list of sites to prioritize for improved pedestrian accommodations, allowing for safe physical distancing in high need areas. This list will be included in a draft letter to be written by David and the others and possibly approved at a special meeting in the next week.

David asked if there were any new places that the Committee would recommend including on the list that had already been identified on the Transportation Board agenda as potential new sites for improved pedestrian accommodations. The Committee members agreed to review the list and get David any suggestions as soon as possible. Frank mentioned Harvard Street between Pleasant and Charles, but noted that it was not "on the table" in terms of its not appearing on the list of new sites to be considered by the Transportation Board. He again expressed confusion about the process for selecting the sites for improved pedestrian accommodations to ensure proper physical distancing during the COVID19 crisis and beyond. David pointed out that as businesses reopen, customers will need outdoor space on public ways for physically distanced queuing while waiting to pick up purchases and orders. David then offered this summary structure for the draft letter he would write:

- We like the idea of improved pedestrian accommodations allowing for safe physical distancing in areas of high pedestrian traffic during this coding crisis and beyond.
- As traffic patterns continue to change for pedestrians, cyclists, motor vehicles and all other public way users, the existing accommodations such as widely spaced temporary traffic cones will not suffice to offer protection to vulnerable users of the public ways. These accommodations need to be implemented in a more effective way if they are to be successful in providing the desired protections.
- Given the current budget crunch it is the recommendation of this committee that the town focuses on high priority areas for these accommodations.
- At this point in the letter the short list of examples (to be compiled by Frank and Robert) will be provided.
- In terms of adding new sites for improved pedestrian accommodations to this list, it was agreed that it's the recommendation of this Committee that the Town implement those accommodations only if they can do it well, for example providing secure perimeters.
- As more public way users using all modes of transportation increase pressure in coming weeks and months the demand for space will make implementing these much-needed pedestrian accommodations more difficult and challenging. Therefore, this committee urges that the town take action as quickly as possible.

Frank and Robert will generate the shortlist, and David will draft the memo in which the shortlist will be included. David will then try to schedule a special meeting of this Committee in the next week to vote on the draft memo to be sent to the Transportation Board in advance of its consideration of these pedestrian accommodations.

5. Jeff Speck's (cancelled) June 8 Presentation to Transportation Board

N/a, although David thanked Frank for forwarding the video of another of Jeff Speck's talks on a similar topic and recommended that everyone view it.

6. Process for Identifying PedAC Priorities

It was decided that each Pedestrian Advisory Committee member choose three items that they consider to be important for consideration by the committee in coming months and send them to the chair in the next few weeks in advance of our July meeting. A lively discussion then took place on how this committee might best communicate with the public. A number of suggestions were raised, including Facebook, Next Door, and the Town Meeting Members list. Kerri Ann suggested that one Town Meeting Member from each precinct be identified as a point person or liaison between their precinct and this Committee, with commitments to disseminate the agenda for this committee in advance of each meeting and to communicate pedestrian related important information from this Committee to constituents residing in each of their precincts. The Committee agreed that effective communication with the public regarding pedestrian related issues was a high priority and committed to carrying on this discussion in future meetings.

7. Updates from Other Groups

Most other groups listed in item 7 on the agenda had not been meeting during the COVID19 shutdown, so there was not much to report. The one exception is the Pedestrian Friendly Street Lighting Committee. Frank Caro reported that this Committee had drafted a report that needs feedback from other groups, beginning with the Pedestrian Advisory Committee. He added that the Pedestrian-friendly Street Lighting Committee would also need advice on how best to implement the agenda that they had identified in that report. He noted that the Pedestrian-friendly Street Lighting Committee was an *ad hoc* committee that would dissolve after the report was accepted and entered into the Town records. He raised the issue of who would then "own" the results of the work of that *ad hoc* committee and put forth the question of whether the Pedestrian Advisory Committee might take ownership of that agenda after the dissolution of the *ad hoc* Pedestrian-friendly Street Lighting Committee. It was agreed to discuss this point at a future meeting.

8. Housekeeping

Committee members agreed that scheduling an August meeting would be less difficult this year than most because of the availability of remote meeting technology. It was agreed to schedule an August meeting. It was also agreed that in advance of that meeting, each Pedestrian Advisory Committee member would commit to personally walking through and observing a zone or area (to be selected at the July meeting) and report back at the August meeting on their experiences and observations.

9. New business

Members of the Pedestrian Advisory Committee expressed serious concerns over the request by the developer for the 370 Harvard Street building project at the KI Temple to eliminate the requirement for audible pedestrian signals, which assist pedestrians with visual impairments. David committed to write a letter to the appropriate Boards and Committees expressing our concern and asking them to retain the important requirement for audible pedestrian signals, the volume of which can be adjusted as needed if abutters eventually complain.

Kerri Ann raised the issue of a high volume of support in precincts 5 and 6 for prioritization of pedestrian access to the Davis Path footbridge, soon to be demolished. She summarized an email exchange on the Emerson Garden neighborhood list where one abutter remarked that the bridge was not "critical" and a chorus of neighbors' responding that it absolutely was critical and needed to be prioritized. David asked Kerri Ann to send him details about this email exchange and will try to ensure that neighbors' strong opinions on this important footbridge are forwarded to the appropriate authorities in the town.

This meeting of the Pedestrian Advisory Committee was adjourned by unanimous vote at 9:04 p.m.

Meeting minutes prepared by Kerri Ann tester.